

Writing a narrative

A NARRATIVE IS A PIECE OF WRITING THAT TELLS A STORY.

A story is an account of events linked by cause and effect. All stories need a narrator, a plot, characters, and a setting. Some stories also include dialogue to show conversations between characters.

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Whose view?

The narrator is the person telling the story. If the narrator is a character in the story recounting the events from his or her point of view, the narrative is in the first person. If the narrator is uninvolved in the story and always refers to characters as *he*, *she*, or *they*, then the story is written in the third person.

First person (main character)

Stories in the first person are often narrated by the main character, or protagonist, of the story.

The scoundrels had deceived **me**, so I made them walk the plank!

The word *his* shows that this story is in the third person.

The ruthless captain made **his** crew walk the plank.

My master is the most fearsome pirate sailing the seven seas.

The word *my* shows that this story is in the first person.

First person (minor character)

Not all stories in the first person are told by the main character. Using a minor character as a narrator gives a different angle.

Third person

A narrative written in the third person tells the story from the author's or an outsider's point of view.

Don't lose the plot

The plot is what turns a list of events into a story. All the events happen for a reason and are caused by the actions and decisions of the characters. A good plot needs to have a clear beginning, middle (usually the main part of the action), and end.



△ Beginning

The beginning introduces the main characters and the situation that they are in. One classic plotline starts with the main character facing a problem.



△ Middle

The middle of the plot often shows the character trying to overcome the problem. The main event or turning point in the plot usually happens in the middle of the story.



△ End

The end brings the story to a resolution. The main character may have solved his or her problem. Alternatively, a plot "twist" may introduce an unexpected ending.